

New from Apple

BusinessWeek suggests that two new versions of the iPhone may soon be released



New by NTT DOCOMO

18 models include various 3G phones including the Evangelion Phone based on an upcoming anime film

100 million handsets are data compatible. However, actual data users are still only about 10 per cent of that number. Although internet usage via mobiles has proliferated substantially since the days of WAP, it's still doubtful whether many would take to it willingly. Primarily, the reason is cost, since mobile browsing is expensive. The basic GPRS service that most carriers provide is really useless since it only allows access to WAP sites. The advanced GPRS service, for which plans start at Rs. 199, lets you access sites on the world wide web as you would on a desktop browser. Subscribing to advanced GPRS lets your installed applications use packet data. However, lower plans have a data limit. For example, the Rs. 199 plan from one operator has no free transfers clubbed and data is charged at 5 paise per 10 kb. Another plan for Rs. 499 allows up to 1 GB of free data transfer. Thereafter, every 10 kb is charged at 5 paise, which works out to about Rs. 5 per Mb. If your data usage is high, only an unlimited plan would make life comfortable for you. Some carriers provide a corporate plan where you get unlimited usage for approximately Rs. 299. If you manage to get your phone under such a scheme then you're set. High-end users will frequently exceed around 1.5 GB of data usage from their phones; so if you're such a user, it's best to look for an unlimited data usage plan. Actually, always look for a genuinely unlimited plan.

Earlier mobile internet enthusiasts would download widgets or applications for accessing specific services online. So you would have an application for Gmail, one for Yahoo, Wikipedia, and so on. The trouble with going this way was that you constantly needed to switch between applications to use the services. We now

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have browsers (both native as well as third party) that give you a full internet experience, and so people are moving away from using widgets and dedicated apps to using browsers just like from their PCs. Most people prefer a third party

browser such as Opera Mini or SkyFire. These display almost all web pages exactly as they would be rendered on a desktop PC only scaled down for a smaller screen. Another similar browser is TeaShark. Its interface is a little jumpy, but many people like it.

There is also the newly released Bolt browser from Bitstream, which is still in beta, but promises a great

browsing experience.

Checking for movie listings is much simpler over the internet using a mobile device than going through the IVR menu of cinema halls. The IVR is painfully slow and often you don't even reach the listing you want. Besides, who wants to bear call charges to listen to a monotonous voice for 15 minutes? Through the web, it's much simpler. You can go to the web site for each of the cinema hall chains such as Adlabs, PVR or Big Cinema and get listings consolidated into one place. Alternatively, you can even install an application



Bookmyshow: booking movie tickets has never been simpler



Connect with Fring

on your phone called b-mobile, from m.bookmyshow.com. This application allows you to select your movie, date, time, quantity of tickets, etc. and even make payments.

Social Connect

When it comes to connecting to chat and social networks, there is an undisputed leader in this space – an application called Fring. It lets you interact with friends on all your favourite chat and social networks such as Skype, MSN Messenger, Google Talk, ICQ, SIP, Twitter, Yahoo and AIM. Using Twitter through this application is also catching on pretty fast. Through Fring you can even listen to music with your Last.fm friends, check out the latest scene on Facebook, and receive Gmail. Through VOIP, which some carriers support, you can even make calls to people. The lag or delays faced are perfectly acceptable, ranging from half a second to a few seconds. So if your friend is logged into MSN, you can talk to him or her through Fring. This way you can even save on airtime costs. Java users can download minifring which is a lite version for J2ME users (m.fring.com). This version does not support VOIP.

Blog connect

Mobile blogging is also catching on with many users today. If you're a regular blogger and want your Wordpress web site to look compatible with a mobile phone browser, you can download a plugin for it. As for blogging from your mobile phone to Wordpress, there have been Symbian apps for a long time. Wordmobi, a Wordpress app for your Symbian S60 device is a good option and so is Scribe; both need Python installed. Blogger, too, has recently joined the bandwagon by enabling a much simpler way to blog from your mobile device. In your blogger dashboard, you will notice two new icons for setting up this service. Click on the envelop icon to set up a custom email address that will automatically be converted to blog posts. This address is something like username.uniquetext@blogger.com. Any email you send to this address from your mobile will instantaneously be posted on your blog. The subject line becomes the post heading, or teaser, and the body text follows. You can even post via MMS. For this, you will need to send a verification code as an MMS to go@blogger.com. There is still no word of a Symbian or Java app for blogger. Sony Ericsson has a native app for blogger, while for iPhone users there is a \$3 app called BlogPress that helps you post to various blogging services such as WordPress, TypePad, LiveJournal and of course Blogger. Speaking of blogging,